

***The Boa and its Petty Enemy:
Contemporary Relationships between
Hindu Nationalists and the Sikhs***

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The image of Hinduism as a boa constrictor crushing in its fold the reformed Sikh religion was conjured up in the early 20th century by the British historian Arthur Macauliffe; it powerfully captures the British Orientalist vision of the relations between Hinduism and Sikhism. It was, incidentally, quickly re-appropriated by the Singh Sabha reformists of the late 19th century in their promotion of a separate Sikh identity. Since then, this fear of 'absorption' into Hinduism has represented one of the recurring themes of Sikh religious and political discourses and has continuously affected the relationships between Hindu nationalists and the Sikhs in contemporary Punjab. And, indeed, Hindu militant organisations from the Arya Samaj to the RSS have been consistent in their claim that Sikhs are an integral part of the Hindu social and religious structure. But whereas the Arya Samaj ideologues were vehemently anti-Sikh, today's RSS has had to keep a low profile in its project to reclaim Sikhism over to Hinduism and is compelled to adjust to the Punjabi-specific context, which is particularly challenging for the Sangh Parivar.

First, Punjab is a Sikh-majority state (62,9 per cent Sikhs, 34,5 per cent Hindus) where Sikhs are dominant socially, politically and economically. Their well-known capacity of mobilisation on community issues, in particular against any perceived threat onto Sikh identity and the two-decade long mobilisation for the creation of an independent Sikh state (Khalistan), has forced the Sangh Parivar to keep a rather low profile in Punjab.

Second, the Punjab has the highest percentage of Scheduled Castes (SCs) in the whole of India: 29 per cent on average, with a peak of over 35 per cent in certain districts of central Punjab. Since the

19th century the four religious traditions present in Punjab, namely Sikhism, Hinduism, Islam and Christianity, have been engaged in a fierce competition to win over these groups at the bottom of the Punjabi socio-religious hierarchy, through proselytism, conversion and reconversion campaigns. Still, today, the issue of conversion of untouchables to Christianity is agitated by the RSS and its affiliates in the Punjab, all the more so that Hindus are a minority in that state.

Third, the Punjab is notable for its negligible proportion of Muslims (1, 2 per cent), whereas it was a Muslim-dominated province before partition. West Punjabi Hindus are very numerous in the Sangh Parivar rank and file and their experience of the uprooting and violence of partition has fuelled its anti-Muslim ideology, all the more so that in the absence of any significant Muslim population, direct confrontation with Muslims as a basis for mobilisation is impossible: what is left is a vehemently anti-Muslim and anti-Pakistani discourse, with few occasions locally to translate it into violent action.

This article will focus on the Sikh response to RSS activities in the Punjab in two respects. First, it will examine the way both sides are engaged in a debate on Sikh identity, which is reminiscent of the late 19th century Arya Samaj–Singh Sabha controversy. Other historical landmarks which have fashioned current relationships between Hindu nationalists and the Sikhs include the partition and the Punjabi Suba (Punjabi province) movement.¹ The 1996 alliance between the BJP and the Akali Dal opened a new era for the Sangh Parivar: benefitting from government patronage, it has developed its activities in the Punjab, especially in the wake of the tercentenary celebration of the Khalsa. Second, the issue of the relations with the Sangh Parivar powerfully discloses the internal diversity, the cleavages and tensions within Sikh ranks. The ‘RSS agent’ label is frequently used to weaken and discredit opponents while the theme of ‘Sikhism in danger’ (of being swallowed up by Hinduism) is used to impose orthodox beliefs and practices onto the Sikh masses.

The Arya Samaj was founded in Gujarat in 1875 by Swami Dayanand to promote a new form of Hinduism based on the

¹ I have decided to leave aside the ‘Panjab disturbances’ of the 1980s, as they have led to the virtual disappearance of the Sangh Parivar from Punjab.

infallibility of the Vedas and the condemnation of idolatry, ritual practices, Brahmin domination and child marriage. Successful in northern India, it has been particularly influential in the Punjab among the urban Hindu elite, which provided much of the leadership and ideological output of the Samaj. According to Kenneth Jones,² the complex relations between the Arya Samaj and its Sikh counterpart, the Singh Sabhas have gone through various phases, from cooperation to conflict (Jones 1973). Several members of the Lahore Singh Sabha, attracted by its reformist ideology, joined the Samaj from its inception. They were drawing a parallel between the 'true' Vedic Hinduism advocated by the Samaj and early Sikhism, defined as a revival of ancient Vedism.

A common concern to prevent conversion to Christianity and Islam served as the basis of cooperation between Aryas and the Sikhs. Swami Dayanand identified conversion as a major threat to Hinduism and to counter proselytising religions turned to *shuddhi*, a traditional Hindu procedure of purification which he transformed into a powerful weapon of reconversion.³ Originally, *shuddhi* consisted in rites of purification of high-caste individuals who had been excluded temporarily from their caste because of polluting actions and transgression of Hindu social norms. *Shuddhi*, therefore, allowed them to be formally reintroduced into their caste. It has been reappropriated by the Arya Samaj and transformed into a powerful tool first, to reconvert individuals born Hindus, later, to convert groups who had never been Hindus at the first instance and significantly as a technique of purification of untouchables to prevent them from leaving the ranks of Hinduism (Clémentin Ojha 1994). Initiated by Dayanand during his stay in the Punjab, where he used it to reconvert a Christian, *shuddhi* was difficult to impose within the Samaj ranks, its moderate wing being clearly reluctant, and was violently opposed by *sanatan* (orthodox) Hindus.

The Singh Sabhas themselves were created in 1873 as a reaction to the proposed conversion of Sikhs students to Christianity. The fear of conversion, of the ensuing demographical decline of the

² The following historical overview draws very much from the reference work of Kenneth Jones on the Arya Samaj, particularly its article on Arya-Sikh relations.

³ On the issue of *shuddhi*, besides Jones (1973), see Clémentin-Ojha (1994).

Panth at a time when the first British censuses were conducted, was a major concern of Sikh reformists and induced them to join the Samaj *shuddhi* campaigns at an early stage to the extent that both groups created a Shuddhi Sabha in the 1880s (Jones 1973).

Later, purification campaigns of groups of untouchables initiated a fierce competition between Aryas and Sikhs which culminated in 1900 with the conversion of the Rahtia (an untouchable caste of weaver) Sikhs to Arya Hinduism which entailed them shedding the external symbols of the Khalsa (with in particular the shaving of hair and beard). Jones very nicely captures Sikhs' uproar against what was perceived as Rahtias' treason and Sikh reformists' attempts to convince the Rahtia leaders to remain within the Panth. The Rahtias' conversion was pointing at as an important issue, a bone of contention between *sanatan* and reformist Sikhs: that is the discrimination suffered by untouchable Sikhs, despite the egalitarian ethos of the Sikh faith as embodied in *amrit sanskar* (the initiation ceremony into the Khalsa brotherhood). The Aryas convinced the Rahtias that their lot would be better if they joined the Samaj. And, indeed, a lot of untouchables were attracted to the Arya Samaj through the upliftment programmes it developed in the Punjab. Ultimately, the conversion of the Rahtias put an end to Arya-Sikh cooperation in the realm of *shuddhi* and reactivated underlying conflicts.

Indeed, the founder of the Arya Samaj, while touring Punjab, had criticised Sikhism and its founder in such harsh terms that they are still resented by Sikhs today. He considered Sikhism merely as one of the many sects within Hinduism, as stated by Jones 'to be noted, refuted and then forgotten' (Jones 1973: 459). The little value he conceded to the ideals and teachings of Guru Nanak had been annihilated, according to him, by the subsequent decline and relapse of Sikhism into mere idolatry:

'Nanakji had noble aims, but he had no learning. He knew the language of the villages of his country. He had no knowledge of Vedic scriptures or Sanskrita [...] [His followers] do not worship idols, but they worship the Grantha Saheb which is as good as idolatry. Just as idol-worshippers have set up their shop in order to get their livelihood, so have these people' (Satyarth Prakash, quoted in Jones 1973: 459).

Punjabi Aryas quickly split between a moderate wing that cooperated with Sikh reformists on the issue of reconversion and

a radical wing that was adamant to prove Dayanand's spiritual superiority. From the middle of the 1880s, as far as Sikhs were concerned, the nuance between moderates and radicals faded away, and the Arya Samaj assumed from that time the violently anti-Sikh outlook it has retained ever since then (Jones 1973). With the polemical tone characteristic of Panjabi debates of the period, the Aryas harshly criticised in their publications, particularly the *Arya Patrika*, what they considered as the current decline of Sikhism, caught up in the same ritualism and superstition as Sanatan Hinduism:

The Khalsa (Sikh) community has undergone many changes since its formation. That sublime and pure faith founded on the Vedas, which was taught by Guru Nanak and his worthy successors has since greatly degenerated. Idolatry has again been introduced, and priest craft in another form has become rampant (*Arya Patrika*, 12 December 1885, quoted in Jones 1973: 469).

As a result of these polemical attacks, Sikhs left the Samaj in the late 1880s and joined the Lahore Singh Sabha.

A major shift occurred at the same period in the debate opposing Aryas and Sikhs that would focus henceforth on the question of Sikh identity. Do Sikhs merely constitute a branch of Hinduism or are they to be considered as a separate religion? In other words, is the Panth a *dharm* (and a *qaum*) or simply one of the myriad of Hindu sects? The Arya Samaj was adamant to prove both that the gurus were well inferior to Dayananda and that Sikhs were nonetheless Hindus. This insistence, combined with the way their publications and speeches debased what Sikhs hold most sacred, 'heightened the Sikhs' sense of self-awareness and separation from Hinduism' (Jones 1973: 467) As I have explained elsewhere (Moliner 2007), the Singh Sabha redefinition of Sikh identity created a new figure of otherness, the Hindu. The point was to demonstrate that the Sikhs were a separate community, distinct from both Hindus and Muslims.

Arya-Sikh controversies and embittered conflicts accelerated the process of identity demarcation among Sikhs, and heightened the Singh Sabha's concern to demonstrate that contrary to Arya's claim, Sikhs were not Hindus. Hence 'Ham Hindu Nahin' (We are not Hindus), a famous Singh Sabha pamphlet published in 1899 in a context of strong antagonism, was written as a response to an Arya Samaj publication of the same year, 'Sikh Hindu Hain'

(Sikhs are Hindus). Written in Hindi, it targeted Hindus as well as Sikhs. Indeed the Tat Khalsa (the radical branch of the Singh Sabha), had indentified another enemy besides the Arya Samaj: what they termed Sikhs ignorance about their true identity, misconstrued as part of Hinduism by *sanatan* (traditional) Sikhs. The position of *sanatan* Sikhs, their very existence in fact, was weakening the Tat Khalsa stand vis-à-vis the Arya Samaj. They were a living proof of the plurality, flexibility and interpenetration of communal identities, characteristic of 19th-century Punjab. Within this complex social fabric, Singh Sabha reformers, at par with other reform movements amongst Hindus and Muslims, strived to impose clear-cut boundaries between Sikhs and other Punjabis.

Besides, this perception by Sikh reformists of Arya activism as the greatest of all threats found an echo in colonial ideology, and was thus legitimised. For instance, one of the recurring themes of British Orientalism is that of Sikhism being in a permanent danger of re-absorption into Hinduism. This 'Sikhism in danger' slogan was re-appropriated by the Tat Khalsa and fed their antagonism with the Arya Samaj. It has since then become a rallying slogan of Sikh ethno-nationalism, particularly during the episodes of confrontation with the (Hindu) state. The most powerful expression of this theme is to be found in a very famous phrase by Macauliffe:

Truly wonderful are the strength and vitality of Hinduism. It is like *the boa constrictor of the Indian forests*. When a petty enemy appears to worry it, it winds round its opponent, crushes it in its folds and finally causes it to disappear in its capacious interior. In this way, many centuries ago, Hinduism on its own ground disposed of Buddhism, which was largely a Hindu reformation; in this way, in a prehistoric period, it absorbed the religion of the Scythian invaders of Northern India; in this way, it has converted uneducated Islam in India into a semi-paganism and in this way it is disposing of the reformed and once hopeful religion of Baba Nanak Hinduism has embraced Sikhism in its folds the still comparatively young religion is making a vigorous struggle for life, but its ultimate destruction is, it is apprehended, inevitable without State support (Macauliffe 1909: 37, emphasis added).

Today, this passage is still frequently quoted within Sikh ranks, especially by those who strongly oppose the RSS (cf., for instance, on www.panthic.com). Held in high esteem by the Sikhs, M. A. Macauliffe is conversely abhorred by Hindu nationalists who hold him responsible for instilling in the mind of Sikhs this 'absurd' idea

of a Sikh separated identity. In this perspective, Sikh religious and political separatism is a mere creation of the British divide-and-rule policy.

Partition and the Panjabi Suba campaign represent two other periods that have been instrumental in fashioning contemporary relationships between Hindu nationalists and the Sikhs. A growing body of literature has been dedicated to the various aspects of partition, and particularly to the memory of partition⁴ and its transmission. I will focus here solely on the role that partition violence in the Punjab has played in the narratives of Hindu nationalists regarding the Sikhs.

The mass violence of partition which mostly opposed Sikhs and Hindus on the one side and Muslims on the other and the resulting exchange of population (the first fleeing to India and the second to Pakistan) is interpreted in Hindu nationalist discourse as a proof written in blood that Sikhs are Hindus, at least during confrontation with Muslims. This point is vividly and polemically made in a pamphlet written in 1955 by Om Prakasha Kahol,⁵ a former member of the Working Committee of the All-India Hindu Mahasabha. In this work published in the wake of the Punjabi Suba campaign, the author argues for the creation of a Punjabi state. He harshly admonishes Punjabi Hindus for opposing it and deals at length with the core issue of language, Punjabi in Gurmukhi script versus Hindi in Devanagari. The fourth chapter is devoted to a 'review of Hindu-Sikhs relations', in particular on the 'eve of Partition'. After stating that the gulf between Hindus and Sikhs was 'widened by Anglo-Muslim conspirators' (1955: 12), it refers to partition violence to support its claim that Sikhs are Hindus.

A Sikh deceives none except himself if he regards Muslims as his better friends than Hindus (...). For a Muslim, they are all 'Kafirs' or Hindus (...). *The academic discussion, whether Sikhs or Buddhists are Hindus or not, is a peace-time luxury. At the time of war, everybody at once comes to know [...] which camp he belongs to* (my emphasis).

The author proceeds to conclude that Sikhs, Buddhists, Jains, Arya Samaji, Sanatanists (orthodox, anti-Arya Samaj Hindus) are

⁴ See, in particular, Pandey (2001).

⁵ *Hindus and the Punjabi State: A Psycho-Political Discussion on the Conception and Rationale of Punjabi State.*

all one and all at war with the Muslims. Clearly, the figure of the Muslim is constructed here as a major unifying element between 'sons of the soil'. Sikhs are Hindus, not merely because Aryas or the RSS say so, but because they were considered as such by Muslims and killed alongside their Hindu brothers during partition. Partition itself is perceived as mere repetition of past conflicts between Sikhs/Hindus and Muslims: 'History repeated itself [(...) to teach them (Sikhs) a lesson they had willfully forgotten (...) They learnt to their cost that the Muslim was the same in the 20th century as he was at the time of Guru Tegh Bahadur or Guru Gobind Singh ...'⁶

The crucial point is to maintain the unity and strength of the 'Hindu nation': indeed, once the Sikhs, Buddhists and Jains are conceded a separate identity, 'then the entire Hindu Nation vanishes' and is reduced to a 'conglomerate of minorities (...) numbering a few lakhs fighting each other under a powerful despotic majority, the Muslims'. Here is an illustration of what Christophe Jaffrelot calls the 'majoritarian inferiority complex of Hindus',⁷ even more acute in the case of Punjabi Hindus. The author then concludes: 'We are a majority against the Muslims if we are Hindus. But we become a minority the moment we discard that unifying word and start our life as Jains, Sikhs or Sanatanists.'

The campaign led by Sikhs for the creation of a Panjabi suba represents a very low point in Hindu-Sikh relations: the position of Punjabi Hindus who staunchly opposed it is still routinely evoked by Sikhs as the ultimate treason, a severe blow to Hindu-Sikh relations and to Punjabiyyat (Punjabi identity).

The Panjabi suba movement was led by the Akali Dal (a Sikh-dominated regional party created in the 1920s) from 1950 till the reorganisation of Panjab in 1966.⁸ It emerged in the nationwide context of the linguistic reorganisation of states, initiated by a major language movement in the Telugu-speaking region of Madras province (now Andhra Pradesh). There is a general agreement that although the Akali leaders presented their demand on a linguistic basis, they were actually campaigning for a separate political status for the Sikhs, through a Sikh-majority state. First rejected for that

⁶ The 17th century, when Sikhs were persecuted by the Mughals: in 1675, Guru Tegh Bahadur, the ninth guru, was executed after he had refused to embrace Islam.

⁷ Jaffrelot (1996: 196).

⁸ The most complete analysis of this period is in Brass (1974: Chapter 6).

very reason in 1953 by the States Reorganisation Commission, their demand would be granted much later in 1966, after an Akali-led agitation, which resulted in communal tensions between Hindus and Sikhs. Besides the communal character of the demand, the Commission based its rejection on the fact that it lacked the support of a majority of the population. And indeed it met with the strong opposition of Punjabi Hindus: as part of the anti-Punjabi suba mobilisation led by the Arya Samaj, they twice returned Hindi as their mother tongue during the censuses of 1951 and 1961.

The Akali-Arya Samaj conflict over this linguistic and political issue is clearly reminiscent of the Arya-Singh Sabha controversy analysed above. As argued in a reference study of the movement,⁹ the Akali leadership's demand was motivated by the long-standing sense that Sikhism was in danger of absorption into Hinduism, and that without a political base, the separate religious and social identity of Sikhs could not be guaranteed — this echoes the already quoted assertion by Macauliffe that without (the colonial) state support, Sikhism's 'ultimate destruction' was 'inevitable'. Among Hindus, Sikh demand revived the recent trauma of partition and the fear of being dominated as a minority in a Sikh-majority state. Interestingly, Hindu nationalists' position on that issue has evolved over time: the RSS and the Jan Sangh first sided with the Arya Samaj and adopted a pro-Hindi stance. But, as Paul R. Brass explains, when it became obvious that Sikh demand would be met by the centre, the RSS leader Gowalkar, during his tour of Panjab in April 1966, engaged Hindus to return Panjabi, in Gurmukhi script, as their mother tongue. And this appeal was based on the long-standing claim that Sikhs are Hindus, after all.

This last-hour shift conveniently allowed for an alliance between the Jan Sangh and the Akalis in the 1967 elections. Beyond electoral considerations, the divergence between the RSS and the Samaj on that issue emerged from a divergence of strategy.¹⁰ The Arya Samaj position was primarily fashioned by the local context: the religious divide (Sikhs versus Hindus) to which the Samaj had made a significant contribution since the 19th century overlapped and was reinforced by a socio-economic divide (Hindus being dominant in cities, Sikhs in rural areas). The RSS and its representatives in Punjab

⁹ Nayar (1966).

¹⁰ I owe the following point to Dipankar Gupta (conversation, Delhi, 3 July 2006).

pursued a national agenda whereby since Sikhs are Hindus, they are to be supported in some of their particularistic demands. To the Arya Samaj, the enemy was the Sikh; to the RSS, it was the Muslim or the Christian. But beyond this divergence of approaches among Hindu nationalists, the Punjabi Suba period notably widened the gap between Hindus and Sikhs of the Punjab and in a sense paved the way for the confrontation of the 1980s.

The final part of our discussion will, first, examine the strategy and the activities of the Sangh Parivar in post-insurgency Panjab and, second, Sikh response to them.

The fieldwork conducted to investigate those issues took place in July and August 2006 in the Punjab and in Delhi. It consisted of interviews with Punjabi Hindus and Sikhs in the following cities: Phagwara, Jalandhar, Ludhiana, Patiala, Chandigarh, Amritsar, Taran Taran and Delhi. I met both 'secular-minded' Hindus (journalists, scholars, politicians, activists) and militants or sympathisers of the following organisations affiliated to the Sangh Parivar: the BJP, Shiv Sena, RSS and Rashtryia Sikh Sangat. Among Sikhs, a few journalists and academics were approached, three Sikh members of Hindutva organisations and several Sikh activists and leaders opposed them.

Different sets of questions were used according to the interviewee. To Hindu militants, the research was presented as an investigation on communal relations between Hindus and Sikhs; and to secular Hindus and to Sikhs, it was presented as a research on Hindutva in the Panjab and Sikh reactions to it.

Contact with the RSS was difficult to establish, and an atmosphere of distrust prevailed during the interviews. The discourse was very monolithic and further investigation or contradiction met with hostility. On the other hand, fieldwork among Sikhs was much easier, and interviewees much more talkative. Aware of my interest in Sikh studies, they were very helpful, providing time, contacts and material (DVD, books, press cuttings and websites) to help me investigate Hindutva activities in the Panjab. Obviously, they were pursuing their own agenda, but discussions were open and lively, and we frequently agreed to disagree.

Hindutva in the Panjab is embodied into three main organisations: the Arya Samaj, the RSS and its related organisations and the BJP.

The Arya Samaj today is both very weak and still powerful. As opposed to the role it assumed in the late 19th century, it is no longer

the representative of Punjabi Hindus' interests. As an organisation, it has nonetheless survived through the DAV (Dayanand Anglo-Vedic) network of schools and colleges, those very influential educational institutions where a large part of the Punjabi elites is educated. But as an ideology, the Samaj is quite alive, as it permeates Punjabi Hindu world view and particularly Panjabi Hindu view of the Sikhs. Interestingly, the Aryas anti-Sikh ideology does not not translate into political terms and hence did not prevent electoral alliances between the BJP and the Akali Dal.

The RSS has been present in Punjab since its creation, and was particularly active in pre-partition West Panjab — most of its cadres and sympathisers originate from there. Besides pan-Indian organisations such as the VHP, Bajrang Dal and Shiv Sena, another satellite organisation called the Rashtryia Sikh Sangat has been launched by the parent organisation to hammer among the Sikh masses the message that Sikhs are Hindus.

These organisations operate in different fields. The Rashtryia Sikh Sangat focuses on the religious sphere; the Bajrang Dal deals with cultural policing; the Hindu Shiv Sena is trying to sustain the Sangh Parivar anti-Muslim rhetoric — mostly targeting neighbouring Pakistan, in the absence of any significant local Muslim population. And conquest of political power is the preserve of the BJP, which has emerged over the years as the third political force in the state. This aspect is crucial to explain the rapid upsurge of Hindutva activities after the period of Sikh militancy. During the 1980s and 1990s, most of these organisations went underground or stopped altogether to operate in the Punjab, after a few Shiv Sena and RSS activists — alongside lay Hindus — were killed by Khalistanis, and many more threatened. In major Punjabi cities such as Ludhiana, the daily RSS *shakhas* had to be interrupted, as RSS members feared for their lives. Since the BJP has entered the regional government in 1997, the almost defunct Sangh Parivar has revived in particular through government patronage. The ostentatious tercentenary celebrations of the creation of the Khalsa in 1999 allowed for the public demonstration of this revival.

The Rashtriya Sikh Sangat,¹¹ created in 1984 in Delhi,¹² in the aftermath of the anti-Sikh pogroms, started its activities among

¹¹ Sangat means congregation, community of faith in Panjabi.

¹² According another account, it was created in 1986 in Amritsar.

the rural Sikh masses: it was entrusted with the task to reintegrate Sikhism into militant Hinduism. To do so, it has chosen the medium of religious imagery shared by all Punjabis. As documented by several Sikh organisations opposing it, the Sangat very skillfully mixes Sikh and Hindu symbols and visual representations. For instance, on banners, posters and pamphlets the Hindu Om is routinely placed side by side with the Sikh Ek-Onkar. Sikh gurus are depicted next to Hindu deities and presented in RSS literature as their avatar. They are also associated with the holy cow: one particular poster depicts the 10 Gurus 'squeezed' into the body of a cow. In religious ceremonies sponsored by the RSS, posters of Sikh gurus are mixed with posters of Shiva or Ram — a practice strictly prohibited in *gurdwara* (Sikh places of worship) although not unusual in Panjabi homes, both Sikh and Hindu. Copies of the *Adi Granth* (Sikh sacred scriptures) were installed in *mandir* to conduct *akhand path*,¹³ and had to be removed when the Akal Takht, the supreme religious authority among Sikhs, banned this practice. The RSS was also debarred from carrying the *Adi Granth* in processions, as is done by Sikhs on specific religious occasions (during *nagar kirtan*, religious parade in the streets).

The Sikh scriptures are indeed a prime target. The RSS presents the *Guru Granth Sahib* as a Hindu scripture, even a national text:

The *Guru Granth* is a big ocean of knowledge, so the RSS has to spread this knowledge. This is why we have sponsored translation in Gujarati, Telugu, Malayalam. We have also reprinted *Sri Bachitra Natak* ... you must know this biography of *Guru Gobind Singh*, where he explains that our ancestors are Ram ...

I call it the national *Granth*, as the whole of India is represented in it. Besides, the gurus are national gurus, they are our gurus, not just the Sikhs'. Socially, historically, spiritually, we are one ... [sic]

— Interview with RSS volunteer in Phagwara, 19 July 2006

The RSS also strives to rewrite Sikh history to present the Sikhs as the sword arm of the Hindu nation. Sikh martyrs receive specific attention and are turned into Hindu heroes: the *Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh*, Jalandhar headquarters' window illustrates this trend. Indeed, it contains portraits of *Haqiqat Rai*, *Udham*

¹³ Religious ceremony consisting in an uninterrupted reading of the *Granth* over 48 hours.

Singh and Guru Nanak. Haqiqat Rai, a young Khatri from Sialkot, was executed in the 18th century in Lahore after he had refused to convert to Islam. To the Sikhs, he is Bhai Haqiqat Rai, one of the many Sikh martyrs of that period. Hindu nationalists call him Veer Haqiqat Rai and claim him as a Hindu hero in the battle against Muslims.

Another bone of contention is the martyrdom of Guru Tegh Bahadur and its contested interpretations. Threatened of forced conversion by Aurangzeb, Kashmiri Brahmins appealed to the ninth Sikh guru for help. The guru's challenge to Aurangzeb ('If you manage to convert me, then all non-Muslims will also embrace Islam') led to his decapitation in 1675. Following historians of the period, I am pointing out elsewhere the polysemic nature of this critical event in Sikh history (Moliner 2007). Indeed, in Sikh historiographic accounts, the conflict was a religious one, between a fanatical Muslim tyrant and the Sikh guru, ready to sacrifice his life for the sake of religious freedom, in that particular instance of a community other than his own. This last point is critical in the debate about a separate Sikh identity opposing Sikhs and Hindu nationalists: the latter used it skilfully to substantiate their claim that Sikhism is an integral part of Hinduism, since the Guru died to protect his own dharma. This interpretation is expounded, among several publications and speeches, in a special issue of *Organiser* on the foundation of the Khalsa: 'The martyrdom of Guru Tegh Bahadur clearly indicates what the identity of (a) Sikh means: Sikh identity is solely and firmly established in the form of protecting the Hindu society and the Hindu dharma' ('Khalsa is the Sword-arm of Hindu Society', 1999). The same article further explains:

Guru Tegh Bahadur never said that the Khalsa was a different sect, different panth. No. We belong to the same all encompassing dharmic tradition called the sanatana dharma [...] There are so many panths, so many sects but they are not exclusive. They are all mutually complementary' (ibid.).

This encompassing, inclusive vision of Hinduism allows the RSS to claim all 'sons of the soil' (Sikhs, Buddhists, and Jains) as Hindus, even if these groups reject that very identification. But there are nuances between the RSS position and that of the BJP, and within the RSS between Hindus and Sikhs.

All of the RSS (Hindu) leaders and militants interviewed denied Sikhs both a political and a religious separate identity.

Sikhs and Hindus are not separate, they share relations of blood. Sikhism has always belonged to Hinduism ... As you know, the first nine gurus were not Singh, they were Hindus. Guru Gobind Singh was a great reformist; he created the Khalsa Panth, because Hindus are coward. At that time, they were persecuted by Muslims ... Did you know that Somnath mandir was attacked 18 times? And what about the martyrdom of our gurus ...

Islamic terrorism has always been the most dangerous thing, since the beginning ...

But what the 10th guru started was the Sikh *panth*, not the Sikh *dharm*.

You know, I am touring Panjab to spread the message that there is no difference, I am doing door-to-door *prachar* (preaching) in so many villages ... these villagers, they listen to me ... I tell them how the RSS has brought nationalism to this country...

— Interview with Sikh member of the RSS, Patiala, 27 July 2006

The illusive sense of a Sikh separate identity, as explained above, was planted by the British into Singh Sabha intellectuals' minds:

Of course Sikhs are Hindus! To the Akalis, they are not ... But it is Macauliffe who brought this idea into Panjab. This is a British conspiracy to divide us.

You know about Macauliffe? He was the principal of Khalsa College. He even took amrit (got baptised into the Khalsa), but he shaved when he went back to England ... And this book *Ham Hindu Nahin*, he is the author of that book

— Interview with RSS volunteer, Phagwara 19 July 2006

On the contrary, another Sikh member of the Rashtryia Sikh Sangat insisted on the distinct religious identity of the Sikhs:

Even RSS has acknowledged that Sikhs are a separate qaum. Culturally, we are close to Hindus, but religiously, we have gone our own way, we do things differently. I believe in Hindu-Sikh amity, that's why I got involved in the RSS ... you know after 1984 ... my house was burnt at that time ... so, yes I believe in unity and amity, but Sikhs are separate!

(— Interview conducted in Delhi, 26 July 2006)

As compared to the RSS's stance, the BJP's discourse is more accommodating, as it concedes a separate religious identity to Sikhs:

Relations between commonplace Sikhs and Hindus have always been cordial. Terrorists tried to create a rift, in the 1988s, but they were not successful ... simply because there are so many strong bonds between them ...

BJP and RSS say: Hinduism is not a religion but a way of life, a broad spectrum that can accommodate Sikhs, Jains, and Buddhists ... It can also accommodate a separate religious identity for the Sikhs ... You know, myself I am a Jain, so ...

Westerners are wrong when they treat Hinduism as a religion ... Hindu means Indian. In that sense, Muslims also are Hindus, they are Hindu Muslims (*sic*)

Interview with former BJP MLA for Chandigarh,
Chandigarh, 12 July 2006

This nuance has probably to be understood with reference to the electoral alliance and coalition politics of the BJP and Akali Dal.

Recent RSS activities in the Punjab have met with very strong opposition from some Sikh groups, mostly factions of the Akali Dal that are usually termed as radical. Besides its political underpinnings, this issue has broader dimensions.

First, it discloses the internal diversity and long standing clivages within Sikh ranks. In that respect, the RSS is used as a device to delegitimise or even demonise opponents.

Second, the RSS stands for all kinds of dangers and threats to the Sikh *panth*, and here assumes a phantasmagoric dimension, in particular through the idea of a Hindu conspiracy to eliminate Sikhs.

Finally, and in relation to this previous aspect, relations with the RSS (and more broadly with Hindus) touches at a core issue which explains the passionate character of Sikh reactions: the issue of Sikh identity, a question still hotly debated within and without the *panth*.

Anti-RSS Sikh organisations are mostly drawn from Akali factions opposed to Prakash Singh Badal, the present Chief Minister of the Punjab: among these groups figure prominently the Akali Dal (Mann), which links the plight of Sikhs with that of other minorities in India, Dal Khalsa (a Khalistani organisation), Khalsa Panchayat and Damdami Taksal (the religious seminary formerly headed by Sant Jarnail Singh Bhindranwale). The anti-RSS mobilisation

also involves various politico-religious actors and traditional Sikh intellectuals — such as the editor of a Sikh publication, Sant Sipahi, the Director of the Institute of Sikh Studies or a former president of the SGPC — all of them interviewed during fieldwork.

The turning point in Sikh mobilisation was the proposed visit of RSS chief Sudarshan in Chandigarh, in 2000, to discuss ‘Sikh agenda’: the above-mentioned organisations formed a Joint Action Committee that launched a major protest in the state capital.

Sudarshan wanted to come to Panjab to discuss ‘Sikh agenda’! ... Would you believe this? What have the affairs of the Panth to do with the RSS? So we decided to teach them a lesson ... to mind their own business, and we formed a Joint Act Committee to prevent him from setting a foot in Chandigarh ... We called a *bandh* (a strike), and we organised massive demonstrations against him ... And you know what, that was the first time something like that happened in the whole of India (activist of the Khalsa Panchayat, Chandigarh).

Since then, every move by the RSS, both the national organisation and its Punjabi offshoot, has been carefully monitored by Sikh organisations. Following that mobilisation, the Akal Takht banned the Rashtryia Sikh Sangat in an edict (*Hukamnama*) of July 2004, forbidding Sikhs to entertain any relation with that organisation. Since then, both the SGPC and the Akal Takht have been under pressure by the dominant faction of the Akali Dal and its ally, the BJP, to withdraw the ban against the RSS.

In a book titled *Taba Ros Jagio*,¹⁴ widely quoted by various Sikh websites and an eponymous CD, Sukhpreet Singh Udhoke documents RSS strategy in the Punjab: he is particularly concerned with what he calls the distortion of Sikh history by the RSS and its ‘denial of the distinct identity of the Sikhs’.

A film about the late Sangh leader Gowalkar released by the RSS at the time of fieldwork (in August 2006), during a press conference in Delhi met with a strong reaction by the Sikhs. In the film, Sudarshan dwells on the violence of partition and the heroic deeds of Sangh activists. As he recalls that Gowalkar ordered them to protect ‘every Hindu’, the film shows, at the same time, Sikhs persecuted by Muslims being rescued by RSS armed men. The Delhi Sikh Gurdwara Management Committee objected to this implicit

¹⁴ ‘I got irritated’, a sentence attributed to Guru Gobind Singh.

portrayal of Sikhs as Hindus and asked that the film explicitly mention that 'Sikhs are a distinct community'.¹⁵

In Sikh discourse, the RSS tends to stand for all contemporary threats facing the *panth*. The main one is that of dissolution, and absorption within the Hindu fold:

Sikhism will never be out of danger. There is this irreversible process that turns Sikhs into Hindus and this process has to be countered endlessly ... that was Master Tara Singh's mission all his life¹⁶. In 1947, he was really scared...You know why? Because, under the British a Sikh could never become a Gora (a white man), it was simply not possible...but now to enter the ruling class, for economic and social benefits, Sikhs will become Hindus ...

The RSS want us to disappear, they say: if Sikhs are to survive, they have to join the Hindu fold ... They say, Sikhs were created to defend Hinduism ... but now that Hinduism can defend itself ... And all these Panjabi Hindus ... before partition, they had no mandir in West Panjab, so they used to go to *gurdware* ... They were calling themselves Sikhs ... and now they say that Sikhs are Hindus!

But you know, we are different, Sikhs have a different psyche. Do you know this story, it is in *Panth Prakash* (Light of the Panth): Abdali, the Afghan invader, was having problems with the Sikhs ... so he asked the governor of Lahore: how to irritate a Sikh? And the governor replied: call him a Lalaji (name for a Panjabi Hindu)!

— Editor of a Sikh publication, Ludhiana

The danger lies, in particular, with the 'amorphous' nature of Hinduism:

Hinduism is an amorphous religion, it is neither prophetic, no scriptural, it is purely ritualistic. All other religions in India are in danger. Look at the fate of Buddhism and Jainism ... these were very clearly defined religions, and they were swallowed by the hydra of Hinduism

— Director, Institute of Sikh Studies, Chandigarh

¹⁵ See 'RSS film projects Sikhs as Hindus' in *Hindustan Times* and Patwant Singh, 'Get Your Facts Right, Mr Sudarshan', *Tehelka*, 2 September 2006. http://www.tehelka.com/story_main19.asp?filename=op090206Get_your.asp, accessed on 29 March 2011.

¹⁶ Master Tara Singh was the leader of the Sikhs from the 1940s till the 1960s, at particularly challenging times for the *panth*.

The definition of a Hindu in the law is perceived as far too wide and inclusive, since 'even illegitimate children of Christians and Muslims are considered as Hindus' (editor of a Sikh publication, Ludhiana).

A very strong sense of threat was expressed in most interviews with Sikh participants, grounded in the acute awareness that Sikhs form a tiny minority in the Indian Union: less than 2 per cent of its total population and a very short and shrinking majority in Panjab, less than 60 per cent:

Let me tell you there is a planned policy to increase the number of Hindus in the Punjab: they are importing labour from Bihar for that purpose. They have even given voting rights to Bihari workers; they can even buy property here.

As far as minorities and Sikhs are concerned, RSS and the Congress are the same, you know ...

This conspiracy is a continuation of 1984. But it is worse, because, if we are outnumbered in the Panjab, everything goes, our history, our culture, our identity. There is now a very thin majority of Sikhs in the Panjab ... And the migrants' influence will increase, our way of life will change ...

To give you an example, now no Sikh candidate could win an election in ... say ... Chandigarh ...

— Akali Dal (Mann) former general secretary,
Ludhiana, 20 July 2006

This sense of threat echoes the 'majoritarian minority complex' of Hindus, alluded to earlier. The threat posed by the RSS tends to assume an encompassing, phantasmagoric dimension. It is held responsible for all the ills afflicting the panth: the continued relevance of caste, ritualistic practices in contradiction to Sikh principles and, more surprisingly, the widespread use of alcohol and drugs or the low literacy rate. Hence, the interview with a Sikh member of the Rashtryia Sikh Sangat took an unexpected turn when one of his friends (a Sikh too) joined the discussion on the issue of Sikh–Hindu relations:

But this is not a religious question ... It is an economic one, between have and have-nots. Sikhs are more prosperous, hardworking ... but

Hindus are more educated, so they want to prevent us from getting proper education, through our own educational institutions ...

(RSS former member agrees) Yes, they don't want Sikhs to get educated!

— Interview conducted 26 June 2006

Conflicts between mainstream Sikhs and Dalits in the Panjab and in the Diaspora (such as during the recent incident in Vienna, in June 2009) are presented as part of the RSS secret agenda to divide and weaken the *panth*, which should be countered by both Sikhs and Dalits:

You have heard about this secret document ... it has been disclosed some time ago ... It was an internal RSS document with a plan to finish the Dalits, to poison their children in schools, to make them mentally retarded ... They do the same with rural Sikhs, through drug addiction and shraab (alcohol) ...

The RSS has different approach towards different minorities. For example, what they did with the Dalits? To enslave the original inhabitants (Ad-Dharmi), the Aryan invaders created the caste system. With the Sikhs, they introduced Brahmanism, casteism ... Caste discrimination is a gift of the RSS to the Sikhs ... (dialogue between an activist of the Khalsa Panchayat and a Dalit friend of his, a trade unionist from Haryana, Chandigarh)

For Sikh — as well as Dalit — militants, the RSS stands for the Hindu 'other', all the more threatening because of his socio-religious closeness. One should not fail to understand that a crucial and complex issue is at stake here, that of Sikh identity, its boundaries and its relation to the Hindu matrix. Both within the *panth* and outside it this question is still fiercely contested.

Indeed, although Singh Sabha version of Sikhism both as a *qaum* (political entity) and a *dharm* (a homogeneous and discrete religious community) has established itself as dominant, its has not entirely succeeded in its project to 'Sikhise' (to borrow Harjot Oberoi's neologism)¹⁷ the Sikhs, as persistent 'heterodox' popular religious practices, tend to demonstrate — such as the popularity of *sants* and *babas* (holy men) — the practice of fast and other propitiatory rituals. In Sikh doctrinal debates, the RSS label can be brandished

¹⁷ Oberoi (1994: 306).

to delegitimise opponents: this is the case in the ongoing debate about the status of the Dasam Granth, the second Sikh sacred scriptures, compiled by the 10th guru. Some portions of this 18th-century work, replete with references to Hindu mythology and to the worship of the Devi by the guru, are obviously at odds with the dominant orthodox version of Sikhism and are dismissed by some Sikh groups as part of the RSS conspiracy to Hinduise Sikhs. The RSS label is hence also used to impose orthodox beliefs and practices onto the Sikh masses.

This article did not have much to say about the real extent of RSS influence in the Punjab, as this original endeavour quickly assumed communal overtones. The Punjabi Hindus interviewed tended to negate it: they claim that the Punjabi context is not prone to extremism and that Hindu nationalism there is of a very mild and moderate nature. On the contrary, Sikhs are concerned with what they term as 'RSS hidden agenda' and its project to infiltrate Sikh institutions. Whereas this contrasted approach does not tell much about RSS real impact, it tells a lot about the communalisation and polarisation of Punjabi elites.

Looking at the Hindutva project from the periphery, from a Sikh-majority state sheds some light on its contradictions, its inclusive (Sikhs are Hindus)/exclusive (Sikhs can only be accommodated if they agree with that) dynamics: in the absence of a significant Muslim population, the Sikh assume two roles, that of the same and at times that of the dangerous other.¹⁸

Sikh responses to that project, while disclosing internal cleavages, illustrate the dynamics of resistance to Hindutva and how this very resistance has contributed to the fashioning of Sikh identity discourses, since the Arya Samaj–Singh Sabha controversy in the 19th century.

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¹⁸ The Christian is also portrayed as the other, the proselytising other, but anti-Christian propaganda does not seem to catch up in the Punjab.

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